Kestrel Talent — Battle Arena strategy note

Team: alpha_beta · **Result:** all 116 slots filled with verified candidates · 1,985 points · 9,876 credits · **score 1,491.2 (#2 of 51 through the closing hour)**

RESULTS IN NUMBERS

MEASURE	VALUE
Slots filled	116 of 116, all verified; 115 signed within 10 seconds of the market opening
Race	129 offers: 116 accepted, 11 lost to rivals who signed first, 2 retried after rate limiting
Verification	192 candidates assessed: 150 passed, 25 fabricated identities, 17 real scores below the bar
Points per signing	17.1, against about 13 for teams that signed at face value
Credits by phase	9,876 in total: recon 6,475 · market-opening race 1,270 · swap pilots 2,131
Score	1,985 − 9,876 × 0.05 = **1,491.2**

HOW THE AGENT DECIDES

One rule drives every purchase: **buy an action only if its expected points exceed its credits × 0.05.** Every threshold in the code is derived from the penalty factor rather than hard-coded.

- **What it buys (recon, while offers are locked).** Search is cheap (1 credit / 100 summaries), so it reads 12 pages per role. Summaries show only skills, so it batch-profiles (60 credits / 50) only candidates with at least 3 of the 6 wanted skills, then applies the bar locally (assessment, notice ≤ 60 days, expected CTC ≤ budget). Candidates who pass on their own numbers are verified with `/assess` (25 credits).
- **Why it verifies.** Measured live: **22% of profiles that looked eligible would have scored zero** (13% failed the identity check, 9% had a real score below the bar). Verification is adaptive: it continues only while *P(fail) × slot value* exceeds its cost.
- **What it signs.** Only candidates who passed `/assess` (identity verified, clean reference, verified score ≥ bar), ranked by a five-term estimate of points (skill match, assessment margin, notes, notice, salary headroom) and de-duplicated by name + city + experience. At the market opening it fired offers best-value-first across all ten requisitions and **filled 116 of 116 within 20 seconds**, losing only 11 names to rivals.
- **When it stops.** When no slot is open and no candidate's value beats its cost. After filling, it spent nothing more except one controlled experiment.

WHAT WE TUNED WHEN THE PENALTY FACTOR (0.05) WAS ANNOUNCED

At 0.05, an assessment costs 1.25 points against a signing worth ~17 (measured), so we verify every signing. Recon depth was set to 12 search pages per role and a queue of 1.25 verified candidates per slot, with recon spend hard-capped at 12,000 credits.

ONE EXPERIMENT, AND WHAT IT TAUGHT US

After the first scores we hypothesised that points ≈ verified assessment margin (it explained 95% of our total). The agent ran a **self-validating pilot**: 10 swaps, each re-checking the replacement was still free before releasing anyone. It predicted +72.6 points; the next refresh showed +11.0. **The agent's own model check rejected the hypothesis (ratio 0.15) and stopped swapping.** Net cost ≈ 95 points, bounded by the pilot design. The two measurements fit *points ≈ 4.19 × (skill + 2.5 × margin + notes + notice + salary)*, each term scaled 0–1.

ROBUSTNESS

Atomic state saves, so a restart resumes without re-buying anything · survived the late opening and the pause (never exits on `closed`; detects a reset from the server's per-requisition counts and re-signs) · rate-limit give-ups are retried later, never treated as failures · a stale candidate costs a 2-credit check, never a refused offer · no requisition ever overfilled · offers priced at 20 credits in the closing hour, with no swaps.

WITH ANOTHER TWO HOURS

Rank on all five terms from the start and profile far more candidates, since the leader's 21.5 points per signing shows the headroom; measure the formula with small deliberate swaps early rather than one late pilot; batch-refresh stale backups (60 credits / 50) before any release.

DECLARATIONS

- **AI assistant:** Claude was used for help in data analysis, writing and testing the agent's code. The team reviewed and approved every deployment and decision.
- **Manual API calls:** before writing the agent, we made five manual calls with our key to learn the response formats, since the OpenAPI response schemas were empty (one each of search, profile, batch, assessment and market: 90 credits, no offers). After that our only manual calls were free ledger and requisition checks; all play was by the agent.